Pollyanna

A simplified retelling

Original story by Eleanor H. Porter

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. Aunt Polly’s duty

After her father died, Pollyanna travelled to Vermont to live with her aunt. Miss Polly Harrington had a comfortable house and strict ideas about duty. She intended to provide for her niece, but she did not expect to enjoy it.

Pollyanna was given a plain attic room rather than one of the beautiful bedrooms downstairs. She noticed its discomforts, but also the view from its window. Her enthusiasm surprised Nancy, the maid, who quickly became fond of her.

Miss Polly planned lessons, chores and suitable behaviour. Pollyanna wanted time to live, which to her meant talking, exploring and discovering things.

She also brought a game her father had taught her. Once, when a charity parcel contained crutches instead of the doll she wanted, he had helped her find something to be glad about: she did not need the crutches. Since then, they had tried to find a reason for gratitude in difficult situations.

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2. A game that travels

Pollyanna explained the “glad game” to Nancy and to people she met around town. She did not always understand the adult troubles she encountered, but she was willing to listen.

Mrs Snow, who was ill and often dissatisfied, expected visitors to find her unpleasant. Pollyanna returned anyway, bringing suggestions and affection rather than merely completing a duty.

She also became curious about Mr John Pendleton, a wealthy man who lived alone and was considered unfriendly. When she found him injured in the woods, she summoned help. Afterwards, she visited him and gradually discovered the warmth beneath his guarded manner.

Not everyone wanted a cheerful answer immediately. Pollyanna sometimes had to learn that another person’s disappointment was not a puzzle she could solve in a single conversation.

Still, her visits changed routines. People began expecting someone to notice them. Being expected and

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remembered made a difference even before anyone found a reason to be glad.

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3. A boy who needs a home

Pollyanna met Jimmy Bean, a boy without a settled home. He wanted a family and useful work. She tried to persuade a charitable group to help him, but their attention was directed elsewhere.

She could not understand why people could discuss helping distant children while overlooking a child standing near them.

Mr Pendleton, meanwhile, had begun to imagine a different future for himself. He wanted Pollyanna to live with him. She thought he might once have loved Aunt Polly and hoped that the adults could make one happy household.

She eventually learned that he had loved her mother, not her aunt. His wish to adopt Pollyanna came partly from that old affection.

Pollyanna did not want to leave Aunt Polly. She could see changes in the house even when her aunt did not speak openly about them. But she had another idea: perhaps Mr Pendleton could offer Jimmy the home he needed.

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4. An old disagreement

Pollyanna’s questions also reached into her aunt’s past. Doctor Chilton cared for people in the town, and he and Aunt Polly had once loved each other. A quarrel had separated them years earlier.

Neither had found an easy way back. Aunt Polly’s strict habits helped keep painful feelings at a distance. Pollyanna did not fully understand the history, but she liked the doctor and wanted him to feel welcome.

Meanwhile, affection showed itself in practical changes. The attic room no longer seemed a suitable place for the child. Aunt Polly began making arrangements that went beyond her original idea of duty.

Pollyanna did not see every improvement as proof of her own influence. She simply enjoyed the growing sense that her aunt wanted her there.

Then an accident changed the household completely. Pollyanna was struck by a motorcar and badly injured. For a time, nothing mattered except whether she would live and what the doctors could do.

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5. When gladness is difficult

Pollyanna learned that she might never walk again. The news overwhelmed her. She could not find a way to play her own game.

Aunt Polly was distressed too. She loved the child and could no longer hide that love behind formal rules. People from the town began visiting or sending messages. Nancy explained what Pollyanna had been teaching them.

The messages told her what had changed. Mrs Snow was finding things she could do for others. Mr Pendleton was going to give Jimmy a home. People who had seemed unfriendly or hopeless had found reasons to try differently.

Pollyanna had believed she was simply sharing a game. Now she discovered that other people could support her when she could not support herself.

Her sadness did not make her ungrateful. It made her an injured child facing frightening news. The people who loved her had to respond to that reality, not demand a smile from her.

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6. A different kind of hope

Doctor Chilton knew a specialist who might be able to help. Old pride and misunderstanding had to be put aside so that Pollyanna could receive the best possible care.

Aunt Polly and the doctor finally spoke honestly. Their affection had survived their years apart. They were reconciled and married.

Pollyanna went away for treatment. Recovery was slow and required work. In a letter, she described the joy of taking steps again. Being able to walk, even a little, meant more than she could have imagined before the accident.

She would return to a home that had changed while she was changing too. Jimmy had a place with Mr Pendleton. Aunt Polly had allowed love to become part of her daily life again.

The glad game had not prevented grief, loneliness or injury. Its value lay in helping people notice something worth holding on to, while accepting help with the things that remained difficult.

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Words to keep

Duty — something you believe you are required to do. Aunt Polly first saw caring for her niece as a duty.

Gratitude — appreciation for something good. The game encouraged gratitude.

Guarded — careful about showing your feelings. Mr Pendleton’s manner was guarded.

Adopt — to become a child’s legal parent. Mr Pendleton considered adopting Pollyanna.

Specialist — someone with particular medical knowledge. A specialist offered another possibility for treatment.

Reconciliation — restoring a relationship after conflict. Honest conversation led to reconciliation.

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A question to carry with you

How can you help someone notice hope without making them feel that they are not allowed to be sad?

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